workforce is believed to have returned to their villages in Saurashtra's Amreli and Bhavnagar districts. Earlier water-starved, the availability of Narmada water has revived farming there. But, says Tank, "for marginal farmers, agriculture remains risky due to climate threats and volatility in market prices of produce". What's a side hustle for them? Gig work in diamond polishing. Shashikant Shah, chairman, LGD Council of India, says almost every second village in these districts has a dozen-odd '*ghantis*' (diamond polishing wheels). By engaging workers there, "diamantaires are trying to reduce cost of production while retaining a trained workforce," he concedes.

WHY SELLERS GO NATURAL

Though almost every exporter and trader now deals with LGDs, Shah says some admit to it and most don't. Surat itself has 14,000-15,000 LGD machines, according to the LGD Council, followed by 400 in Mumbai, 200 in Jaipur, 25 in Delhi and 200 being planned in Hyderabad. "With new companies and different brand names, the younger generations educated abroad have taken to LGDs. But the 30-odd big diamantaires have an inventory of natural diamonds worth Rs 200 crore each, so they aggressively defend the traditional system," he adds. That's led to a paradoxical push: resources have been diverted to marketing natural diamonds over LGDs, a campaign that's yielding some results. In a slack global market, India has risen over China as the second largest destination for the genuine article. But Shah believes the future potential lies with LGD. Survival remains key for all players—whether at the top or the bottom of the pyramid. ■



Takeaways

- **The Thackeray cousins reunite after a two-decade estrangement; Raj credits it to Fadnavis's Hindi policy**
- **An alliance forecast for polls to cash-rich BMC et al**
- **Sena UBT, MNS fighting together can galvanise the old Sena base emotionally**
- **Counter-mobilisation of non-Marathis biggest risk**

Hindi handed the duo a strong adhesive. The BMC, central to the old Sena's politics and its "reward economy", is another. "Fadnavis managed to bring us together, something even Balasaheb could not," said Raj at a July 6 rally in Worli. Uddhav said they had "come together to stay together".

THE MARATHI GENE

The old Sena is described as an "emotional party", so a joint campaign can create an upsurge among its core Marathi vote. The language move was said to be Fadnavis's brainchild, a bid to appease the powerful Hindi lobby and land a larger national profile. It seems to have boomeranged. A section of Marathi voters, including elite castes and OBCs, could prefer the Thackerays.

For all his slim electoral pickings, Raj has strong pockets of support. He also has serious street cred and machismo, precisely the qualities seen to have drained away from Uddhav's camp post Shinde's desertion. What's to be seen is if the MNS brawn can be stacked onto the Sena UBT's support base, with its auxiliary constituency of Muslims et al.

The Thackerays have not spelt anything out clearly. But a UBT elder says an alliance seems a natural corollary. "However, the BJP will try its best to woo Raj. Note that while BJP leaders went all out in attacking Uddhav after the rally, they have been soft on Raj," he says. In case of an alliance, the elder cousin will have to do much of the adjustments. The MNS has no MLA, nor a corporator in Mumbai. The two also share spheres of influence in areas like Parel, Dadar, Mahim, Sewri and Bhandup, making seat-sharing tough.

VS. THE REST OF MUMBAI

One bulwark against this: a counter-mobilisation of non-Marathis. Gujaratis, Rajasthanis and Hindi speakers, put together, boast more numbers, says a state minister—and they are "solidly pro-BJP". Maharashtrians, estimated at 35-40 per cent of Mumbai's population, are divided among parties. Analysts feel the Muslims, who helped the Sena UBT save face in almost all the 10 assembly seats it won in Mumbai, may emerge as the crucial link. A BJP leader says the Thackerays are "clutching at straws". There are also those like journalist Nikhil Wagle who say their unity will be the last straw for Shinde. ■